

Generative AI and Accessibility Workshop: Surfacing Opportunities and Risks

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Abstract

The increasing use of generative AI (GAI) as an accessibility tool offers transformative opportunities, but it also introduces significant risks and barriers that remain unaddressed. This workshop explores the multi-faceted nature of GAI use for accessibility, focusing on its potential to create access solutions where none exist while surfacing the risks of bias, inaccessibility, and misinformation. Our goal is to establish best practices for inclusive GAI design that centers disabled people's agency, addressing key questions such as how to ensure GAI tools are accessible by default and how to mitigate risks without undermining autonomy. By bringing together experts in accessibility, AI, human-computer interaction (HCI), and disability studies, this workshop aims to develop design guidelines, recommendations, and practices that will influence future GAI systems. Participants will collaboratively define an agenda for creating GAI tools that advance equity, minimize harm, and embrace the diverse needs of the disability community.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Accessibility design and evaluation methods.**

Keywords

Generative AI, Accessibility, Accessibility technologies

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1 Introduction and Background

The adoption of Generative AI as an accessibility tool has grown in recent years. GAI-based apps such as BeMyAI [4] and Seeing AI [26], as well as consumer products such as Meta AI Smartglasses [25] and OpenAI's ChatGPT [27], have reached commercial adoption and large user bases. A growing body of work has begun to document GAI's utility as a tool for accessibility [1, 8, 12, 19, 29, 36]. Glazko et al. through group autoethnography surfaced promising areas for GAI use for accessibility when GPT-4 emerged in Spring 2023, finding that the use of GAI improved accessibility of tasks such as image design, visual description, and communication support—while remaining mixed or inaccessible or text summarization and GUI design and development [12]. Additional work has explored the usefulness of emerging GAI tools to specific groups of disabled people, both in daily life and specific contexts. Several works have demonstrated GAI's usefulness as an accessibility tool for autistic people, with participants showing preferences for the tool over human support in communication [19], and as a support for managing daily tasks and social relationships [8]. Others have explored its use by Blind/Vision Impaired (BVI) people for use in daily tasks such as interpreting visual information online [13, 33, 34, 38] and in the physical world [6, 7], gaining fashion advice [36], minimizing cognitive load and effort of demanding tasks [20, 36], and creating visual content [1, 12, 15, 16, 18]. It has been proposed as a tool for song-signing for use by Deaf/Hard-of-hearing (DHH) people or ASL interpreters [9], and as a tool for people who use AAC devices to provide phrase starters [32] and sentence completion [31] to improve agency in communication. Additionally, the use of GAI-based chatbots has been documented as a tool for improving mental health outcomes for students with mental health conditions [24]. These works illustrate abundant opportunities for GAI to create new avenues for accessibility, where no existing solutions exist [12], or where alternatives such as human support exist but are limited or not preferred [1, 19, 24].

Yet, much of this same body of work acknowledges notable risks and barriers to accessibility that exist in GAI use for this purpose. Some of the issues surfaced in these works include receiving inaccurate information from outputs [7, 12, 17], over-reliance and

dependence [8, 22], opting for lower-quality results [31, 32, 37], harmful advice [30], or encountering bias and stereotypes [12]. An emerging body of work focuses on evaluating the ubiquity of such risks and barriers to access, including inaccessible interfaces and interaction modalities [3]; inaccessibility of information due to literacy and cognitive barriers [28]; ableist and inaccurate portrayal of disabled people in GAI as horrific, solitary, and always in wheelchairs [23], falling into tropes such as “inspiration porn” [10], or associating neurodivergence with negative traits [5]; potential for negative mental health outcomes [22, 30]; risks of misinformation from erroneous outputs [17]; and overdependence [14]. Glazko et al. described how concerns such as the inability to validate GAI outputs independently posed accessibility barriers to users, especially in contexts where the original source material was inaccessible [12]. Huh et al. describe the discrepancies between perception of accuracy of output in BVI users and actual accuracy — with the length of the output as an impactful, yet misleading factor in trusting GAI outputs [17]. Alshaigy and Grande raise concerns about how inaccessibility interacting with GAI; such as inaccessible user interfaces, lack of alt text for generated elements, lack of support for alternative input methods; result from lack of engagement with the disability community during the development and testing of popular, widely-adopted GAI tools [3].

As issues remain unaddressed, disabled people have found approaches to de-risking GAI for accessibility. Alharbi et al.’s emerging work documents the errors which BVI people experience when interacting with GAI, and approaches they have developed for themselves to validate outputs, including avoiding use for high-risk tasks, using tactile clues for confirming outputs, verifying with other people, or using additional apps or tools [2]. Glazko et al. attempted to mitigate disability bias present in GPT-based resume screening by instructing a custom GPT to not exhibit disability bias [11]. These disparate examples of mitigating risk to disabled people in GAI use share an attribute of being designed by disabled people, outside of the existing design or default user experience of the GAI tool. Emerging work has begun to demonstrate the promise of using GAI to automate and ease validation. Huh et al. demonstrated a novel use of GPT-4 to aid in prompt validation of AI-based image generation and summarizing visual information, yet work remains in integrating validation into the process of editing prompts and fixing erroneous outputs [16].

There remains an unanswered question of how the risks GAI tools pose to people with disabilities can be addressed by the development of the GAI tools themselves [3]. Additionally, a critical reflection on whether GAI accessibility tools have been development with empowerment of disabled users in ways that allow for self-determination and agency in interaction [21] is needed. Key gaps in disabled involvement in the development of GAI tools [3] necessitate evaluating the development of GAI tools to assess if they foster agency and avoid harm to disabled people; instead centering their needs, voices, and participation in the process [35]. This workshop aims to explore and develop goals for the principles of developing of GAI tools that empower disabled people and meet their access needs while minimizing risks such as inaccessibility, inability to validate outputs, harmful outputs, and biases/stereotypes as part of their design.

The goals of this workshop are to develop an agenda for inclusive, accessible design of GAI tools with disabled people in-the-loop and launch a survey of best practices for designing GAI tools that minimize risks and empower disabled people. We plan to consolidate our findings into a position paper that informs the GAI community on the current risks and lack of accessibility posed by existing GAI tool designs and puts forward recommendations on designing inclusive GAI tools across a variety of disabled identities and support needs.

2 Workshop Goals

Our goal is to **establish a proactive, equity-promoting agenda for the design of GAI tools**, focusing on enhancing accessibility and minimizing inherent risks to people with disabilities right from the developmental stages. This area remains underexplored, with major issues like inaccessible interfaces [3], lack of built-in, multi-modal validation [2, 12], and disability biases [11, 12] that remains unaddressed in commercial GAI tools. Additionally, community-wide problems such as the lack of engagement with disabled people during the design and testing phases of GAI development [3] have not been addressed in the existing body of work.

We aim to **surface and synthesize barriers to accessibility and risks of GAI to disabled people**, in the context of its vast opportunities for creating new accessibility solutions [1, 12, 19]. The prior body of work in this domain has raised accessibility barriers and risks specific to the domain of use, or particular types of support needs (e.g., lack of screenreader support). However, there is a noticeable gap in integrating these findings into overarching design goals or actionable recommendations, which our agenda seeks to address. By consolidating these insights, we will develop comprehensive guidelines that not only mitigate risks but also enhance the user experience for people with disabilities.

Through our workshop, we aim to address the following :

- (1) **How can we design GAI tools that foster opportunities for accessibility?** We will explore tool design approaches that address accessibility from the ground up, instead of retrofitting existing tools for non-disabled users to meet the needs of disabled users. This includes discussing inclusive design principles and identifying key features that support diverse user needs.
- (2) **How can we identify risks in earlier stages by engaging broad end users?** It is important to prioritize early engagement of a diverse group of users, specifically including those with disabilities, in the initial phases of designing and testing GAI tools. This approach is crucial for detecting potential issues early on, rather than after widespread deployment. We will discuss how we can identify and address accessibility and ethical risks, analyze biases in AI models, and develop ongoing validation strategies.
- (3) **How can we create sustainable frameworks for continuous feedback and iteration?** To manage and mitigate further risks in a sustainable manner, we will establish processes for ensuring that GAI tools remain accessible over time through continuous feedback loops and iteration. This involves creating channels for ongoing user input, particularly from users with disabilities, to inform future tool improvements and updates.

- (4) **How can we empower users through inclusive design that promotes agency without patronizing?** We will discuss approaches that empower users with disabilities, focusing on designing systems that enhance user agency without being overly paternalistic. This includes developing strategies for balancing assistance with autonomy and ensuring that users retain control over their interactions with GAI tools.

Addressing these questions requires an understanding of accessibility and disability and their interactions with GAI technologies. Thus, we will welcome and encourage contributions from people with expertise in accessibility, HCI, AI, ML, design, disability studies, social studies, and lived experience with disabilities, neurodivergence, mental conditions, physical health conditions, and more to promote the exchange of knowledge and collaboration between researchers with domain expertise in diverse areas.

In addition to the listed questions, we would like to spur discussion on around addressing these key themes while navigating divergent preferences, access to alternative support (e.g., human support), comfort with technology, and privacy that vary across disabled people. We will encourage broader discussion around additional potential harms and risks to disabled people through GAI use, such as concerns around sustainability and impacts on wellness and livelihood, as well as opportunities for improving accessibility of these same concerns through GAI tools.

3 Organizers

Kate Glazko is a Ph.D. student in the Allen School of Computer Science and Engineering at the University of Washington, Seattle. Kate is part of the Make4All lab, studying the use of Generative AI tools for creating novel opportunities for accessibility in domains where there are limited solutions, such as design for fabrication, and the risks and harms of real-world GAI use to people with disabilities. Kate identifies as neurodivergent and disabled.

Mina Huh is a Ph.D. student in the Department of Computer Science at The University of Texas at Austin. Through her work, she explores how GAI-powered tools can empower BVI creators in visual content creation and evaluates how emerging GAI technologies such as large vision-language models either support or fail to meet the needs of BVI user to equalize the benefit of such models. In her research, she conducts need-finding studies and evaluations with end users with disabilities to ensure her systems address core accessibility challenges in effective ways.

Jazette Johnson is a postdoctoral scholar at the Paul G. Allen School of Computer Science and Engineering at the University of Washington. Her research bridges human-computer interaction and accessibility, focusing on the design of online social support systems for vulnerable communities. Currently, she investigates the risks posed by Generative AI, specifically misinformation, and its impact on people with disabilities. Jazette's work aims to inform ethical guidelines and inclusive AI design to ensure equitable access and safety for underrepresented populations.

Amy Pavel is an Assistant Professor in the Department of Computer Science at The University of Texas at Austin (Main contact person). As a systems researcher in Human-Computer Interaction

and Accessibility, she focuses on embedding machine learning technologies, such as Natural Language Processing, into new human interactions, which are then deployed for testing. Her systems enable remote content creators to collaborate more effectively, assist video authors in efficiently creating accessible descriptions for blind users, and support instructors in helping students learn and retain key concepts. To inform the design of future systems that capture the needs of domain experts and people with disabilities, she conducts and collaborates on in-depth qualitative studies, co-design processes, and quantitative studies. Her research goal is to enhance communication, making it both effective and accessible.

Jennifer Mankoff directs the Center for Research and Education on Accessible Technology and Experiences and is a Professor in the Paul G. Allen School of Computer Science and Engineering at the University of Washington. Her research is focused on accessibility through giving people the voice, tools and agency to advocate for themselves; and she herself identifies as disabled. She strives to bring both structural and personal perspectives to her work. For example, her recent work in fabrication of accessible technologies considers not only innovative tools that can enable individual makers but also the larger clinical and sociological challenges to disseminating and sharing designs. Her recent work has focused on accessibility in domains such as AI and fabrication.

4 Website

We will host an accessible website for this workshop to initially invite participation and share our call for contributions. Later, we will host selected submissions with the permission of the authors on the website. Our workshop's website URL will be: <https://accessgaichi.com/>. We will make our website fully accessible to screen reader users and users with color vision deficiencies.

5 Plans to publish workshop proceedings

For authors of accepted papers who give permission to do so, we plan to publish accepted submissions on the workshop website. We may additionally publish a collection of the submitted papers as workshop proceedings via <https://ceur-ws.org> or Arxiv. We will encourage authors to follow SIGCHI accessibility guidelines for authors¹.

6 Pre-workshop plans

We will promote this workshop to accessibility-oriented communities within SigCHI as well as established communities of neurodivergent and disabled scholars within the HCI/computing community such as the Disabled in Computing, ADPHD, and the Disabled Academic Collective. We will also advertise the workshop through groups such as AccessComputing, CREATE, DO-IT, who have participants with diverse identities including disability. To reach diverse participants in AI/ML communities, we will advertise through social networks and email lists of relevant conferences and communities including but not limited to FAccT, Queer in AI, Queer in Robotics, and directly share the workshop with our own networks.

We will have a mailing list for communicating workshop information, including important dates and deadlines, with participants.

¹<https://sigchi.org/resources/guides-for-authors/accessibility/>

Additionally, we will leverage this communication channel to communicate with asynchronous participants who are not able to attend the workshop.

Workshop participants will need to submit a short paper (1-6 pages) or existing work matching the call (no page limit). We will consider submissions including position papers, extended abstracts, personal experience reports, industry perspectives, or demos of systems that align with our workshop's theme. We will use Google Forms to collect submissions and communicate acceptance status through email. Two organizing team members will review each submission. Accepted submissions will have an opportunity to be shared at the workshop, either in the form of a short presentation or an in-person or virtual poster session, depending on the significance of the contribution and alignment with workshop themes (described in more detail in the Workshop plan section). Before the workshop, we start our asynchronous communication channel (Slack or Discord) to share accepted submissions with participants and encourage early introductions.

As organizers of a workshop centered on accessibility, we are committed to inclusion and meeting accessibility and support needs. The described technologies and communication platforms will be selected to meet accessibility best practices as broadly as we are able to, yet we are aware that the technologies listed may not meet everyone's accessibility needs, and that fluctuating access needs may necessitate alternative solutions. We are prepared to work with our participants to find solutions that meet their needs.

7 Workshop activities

The workshop activities will be designed for 35-50 participants and will be structured around i) group brainstorming of recommendations for furthering GAI as an equitable accessibility tool and minimizing risks and access barriers, ii) collaboratively drafting design guidelines for GAI built with disabled inclusion as a priority, and iii) initiating outlining and literature search for the GAI accessibility survey paper based on the emerging themes. We will also feature poster presentations and guided discussions aligned with the workshop's key questions and themes. With the authors' consent, we will distribute accepted submissions to workshop participants in advance of the workshop.

We will organize our workshop as a half-day, hybrid workshop running from 9 a.m. to 1 p.m. in the conference's local time. We will structure the workshop so that collaborative group activities such as design exercises, discussions, collaborative writing, and future planning take place in the morning part of the workshop, with an optional poster session held during lunch. To be inclusive of participants unable to participate synchronously due to time-zone differences, we will host an additional, fully-remote, 2-hour pre-workshop supplemental session in "Pacific Standard Time" at the start of the week before the conference. We expect some participants will join the main workshop in-person, and others will choose to join remotely. For hybrid, synchronous participation, we will use Zoom. During the workshop, we aim to create an interconnected experience during the breakout sessions for both in-person and virtual attendees. Each physical table will have one tablet or computer that streams the Zoom session, ensuring that the remote participants can fully engage with participants in-person. To help

facilitate smooth interactions, we have designated two organizing committee members to lead these interactions, where one attending remotely will lead the virtual breakout sessions and the other on-site will serve as the liaison between the virtual and in-person spaces. This hybrid setup allows for a collaboration between all attendees, regardless of location. We will also host a conversation server (Slack or Discord) for our participants that will open at the time of workshop selection notification, to encourage asynchronous participation, idea-sharing, and networking in advance of and spanning the time of the workshop. We will work with participants and CHI organizers to ensure that accessibility needs for participation (e.g., captioning, interpreters, PDFs of presented materials) are arranged in advance of the workshop.

Schedule of pre-workshop discussion session (PST time)

- 15 minutes (Introductions)
- 20 minutes (Experts panel on GAI and accessibility)
- 5 minutes (Break)
- 45 minutes (Parallel small group design exercises)
 - How do we design GAI to be accessible by default? What is missing?
 - Agency, equity, and diverse needs– how to center disabled people
 - Surfacing GAI risks and opportunities in accessibility experience in mitigating GAI risks
- 5 minutes (Break)
- 30 minutes (Group share-out, consolidate insights into higher-level themes or recommendations)
- 10 minutes (Conclusion and next steps)

Schedule of hybrid workshop (local time)

- 09:00-09:15 15 minutes (Introductions)
- 09:15-09:30 15 minutes (Posters, networking, break)
- 09:30-10:30 60 minutes (Parallel small group design exercises)
 - How do we design GAI to be accessible by default? What is missing?
 - Agency, equity, and diverse needs– how to center disabled people
 - Surfacing GAI risks and opportunities in accessibility
- 10:30-10:40 10 minutes (Break)
- 10:40-11:10 30 minutes (Group share-out, consolidate insights into higher-level themes or recommendations)
- 11:10-11:50 40 minutes (Parallel small group writing exercise, planning survey paper next steps)
- 11:50-12:00 10 minutes (Closing and coordinating future work)
- 12:00-13:00 60 minutes (Lunch, optional poster presentations)

The preliminary schedules for the remote pre-workshop session and hybrid main workshop session are detailed above. Since the primary goal of the workshop includes collaborative ideation and creation of a research agenda, substantial time in both the pre-workshop session and hybrid workshop is dedicated to group discussions and design exercises, collaboration, and share-outs. The pre-workshop discussion session will begin with a group introduction followed by an experts panel on GAI and accessibility, to introduce the group to a diverse set of experiences and viewpoints.

The invited panelists will include experts in accessibility, human-centered AI, or related fields, as well as those who have explored the intersection of AI and accessibility. The panelists will represent diverse areas of expertise, spanning academic and industry research, and lived experiences, such as people who use AI for accessibility. This will be followed by the main activity, a small-group design exercise where participants can select one of the three separate tracks listed to participate in, where they will jointly explore literature and existing solutions and put forward a set of design recommendations or implementation techniques. This exercise will be followed by a group share-out and discussion of broader themes and recommendations, and conclude with a discussion of the next steps. The results of the design exercises will be documented and shared with all participants through our asynchronous communication channel.

The hybrid workshop will start at 9 a.m. local time with group introductions followed by a brief poster and networking session to encourage exchange of ideas and information prior to the design exercises. We then shift into a continuation of the collaborative design exercise conducted during the pre-workshop—participants who attend both will be able to select a different track to explore, or continue where they left off with new team members— including time for discussion of the opportunities and risks of GAI to people with disabilities, and the importance of disabled agency and centering the disabled experiences in GAI, with parallel, group design exercises on building more inclusive, accessible GAI based on these guiding discussions. We will follow with a larger-group share-out of the design exercise results, collating them into broader themes and recommendations and setting the framework for a future survey paper. We will follow this group activity with a parallel, small group writing exercise for planning survey paper next steps, creating outlines for key themes, and identifying core literature. We will wrap up with a closing and coordination of future work. An optional lunch with poster presentations and networking will follow. All accepted submissions will be given opportunities to display posters either in-person at lunch or on our website.

Group activities and discussions will be led by workshop organizers. At least one workshop organizer will actively engage with hybrid, synchronous participants on Zoom. We will leverage digital tools for our group ideation and discussions, such as Google Documents, to ensure information is captured in ways that will be readily available and accessible to hybrid participants. We will also encourage in-person participants to engage with our asynchronous discussion channels (Slack, Discord) during the workshop. Organizers will take detailed notes during the workshop, and ensure they are available to participants following the workshop.

8 Post-workshop plans

- **Sharing Deliverables:** The organizers will post a detailed summary of the workshop's discussions and activities on the website or a medium blog. Participants interested in deeper engagement will collaborate on writing a comprehensive position paper, white paper, survey paper, or case studies to solidify the workshop's contributions into tangible forms. We will encourage participants to archive such deliverables and link to our website.

- **Maintaining Communication and Collaboration:** A dedicated communication channel (such as Slack, Discord, or an email list) will be maintained to facilitate ongoing dialogue and collaboration among participants, ensuring the momentum generated during the workshop is sustained.
- **Sustaining and Extending the Workshop Impact:** We will make efforts to organize follow-up workshops at future conferences, aimed at expanding the reach and depth of the workshop's themes and fostering a continuous evolution of the discourse around GAI accessibility.

9 Call for participation

“Generative AI and Accessibility Workshop: Surfacing Opportunities and Risks”

Join us for the **Generative AI and Accessibility Workshop** at **CHI 2025**, where we will explore the potential of Generative AI (GAI) for improving accessibility while addressing its risks. This half-day hybrid event will feature small-group discussions and collaborative design and writing activities. The workshop is open to both in-person and remote participants.

Participation: A maximum of 45 participants will be selected based on their paper submissions. We welcome position papers, in-progress work, extended abstracts, personal experience reports, industry perspectives, or demos. Submissions should be made via Google Form by **March 12th, 2025**.

More Information: Visit our website at <https://accessgaichi.com> for more details.

Accessibility: Contact the organizers for specific requests.

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